Vivek Katju, who later became the joint secretary on the Pakistan, Afghanistan, Iran desk (JS PAI), and India's first ambassador to Afghanistan after 9/11.[160] A 1974-batch diplomat, Katju was considered a hardliner on Pakistan, had developed close links with the UF, and was staunchly anti-Taliban.

Salman Haidar, Raghunath's predecessor as foreign secretary (March 1995 to June 1997) gives a similar assessment of the situation. 'Our relationship with Afghanistan, as I understand, has a lot to do with Indo-Pak relations ... The Afghan civil war was a time when this was very visible. Pakistan was backing the Taliban, we hated the Taliban, and the Taliban was seen as a group damaging Indian interests'.[161] The key reason given for this emotion of 'hate' was the 'unstable situation in Kashmir' where 'there was plenty of tinder'. When asked why India did not engage the Taliban knowing well that this could raise the Taliban's stake in supporting Kashmir insurgency, Haidar says that while 'the logic of what you [author] are saying is absolutely correct, but the time was not right ... I don't think the situation had developed to the point where some exploration of differentiating between different types of Taliban and different types of groups within Afghanistan was possible ... Terror meant Taliban'.[162]

According to Shyam Saran, foreign secretary from August 2004 to September 2006 (but who played an important role even in the 1990s), the Taliban was 'seen as trying to exclude India from Afghanistan and prove[d] to be very hostile to India. That is one of the reasons why India withdrew its diplomatic representation from Afghanistan. And during that period also saw its interests in supporting the Northern Alliance (United Front).'[163] Haidar, Raghunath, Katju, and Saran, all concur that not only did India view the Taliban as a hostile entity but also wanted to work towards containing its rise. Lalit Mansingh, foreign secretary between December 1999 and March 2001, adds that India 'lost all contact with Afghanistan during those six years'.[164] This was despite Saran's assertion that India's outlook towards Pashtun communities was not altered by the rise of the Taliban, and that 'not all Pashtuns are Taliban or not all Pashtuns are fundamentalists'.[165]

These statements reflect India's historical links with Pashtun elites. Most interviewees within and outside India's state establishment corroborate this viewpoint. However, most Pashtun leaders that officials recall as being close to